

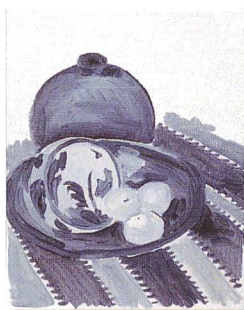
PAINTING IN LAYERS

IF YOU ARE NOT USED to building up a painting in layers, you should keep two things in mind. First, always wait until a paint layer is completely dry before overpainting it with another color, and second, add a drop or two more of your oil painting medium to your paint mixtures as you work up through the layers of color. This ensures that each layer is slightly more flexible than the one below, and is

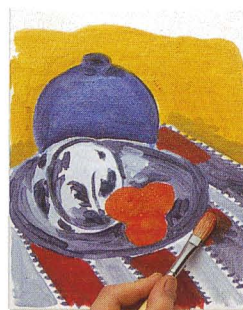
known as the “fat-over-lean” rule. Although there are many ways of painting in layers, one method is to sketch an image in diluted color and then paint in the broad areas of tone with a transparent or monochromatic technique. When this is dry, color can be added and paler tones worked in. Once these layers are dry, final applications of transparent glazes and opaque highlights can be added.

APPLYING A GLAZE

Transparent oil glazes should not simply be brushed on and left; they usually have to be manipulated with a brush on the support to give a uniformity of tone, even out the degree of color saturation, or reduce a thick glaze to a light stain. A blending brush, or a clean shaving brush, is good for dabbing and smoothing the glaze. When you mix a glaze, add a glazing or painting medium to the paint to make it more malleable. Once you have painted on the glaze, wait for a few moments so that some of the solvent in the painting medium can evaporate. Then use the shaving brush to manipulate the glaze and smooth away visible brushmarks. If you only need to glaze a small area, use a small round or flat soft hair brush instead.



1 An underpainting in one color can be useful as it allows you to concentrate on form and tone first, rather than color.



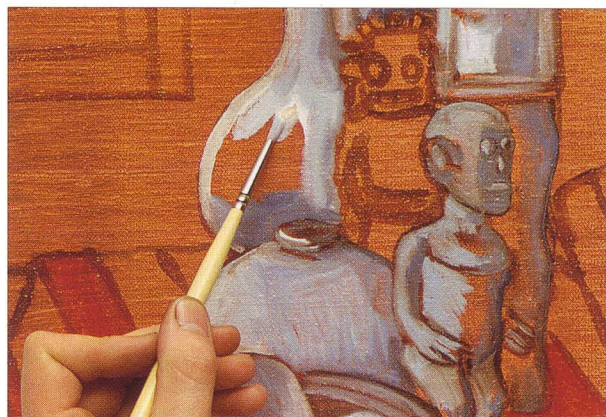
2 Once the underpainting is dry, apply color over the different tones with a large bristle brush.



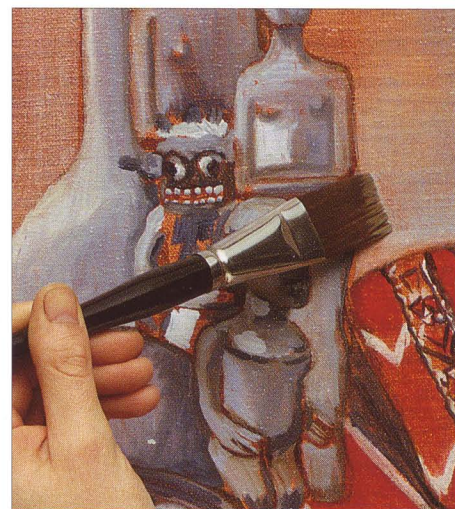
3 Smooth the glaze over the surface with a large, flat round brush, such as a shaving brush.

Building up layers of color

A still life is a good subject to choose if you want to practice painting in layers, because you can leave the composition set up for as long as you need while you wait for individual layers of paint to dry. This study is built up over a colored ground to give the layers of color a subtle accent. A monochromatic underpainting helps to establish areas of light and dark before any colors are applied. Mix each glaze you use with a little oil painting medium.



1 Sketch the composition in with a thin mix of Burnt Umber and then use a small round bristle brush and a range of gray tones to build up a tonal picture of each object in this still life.



2 When the underpainting has dried, mix individual glazes of color and apply them with a large, flat, synthetic wash brush. If you prefer, use a new brush for every glaze so that you can retain the purity of each color.